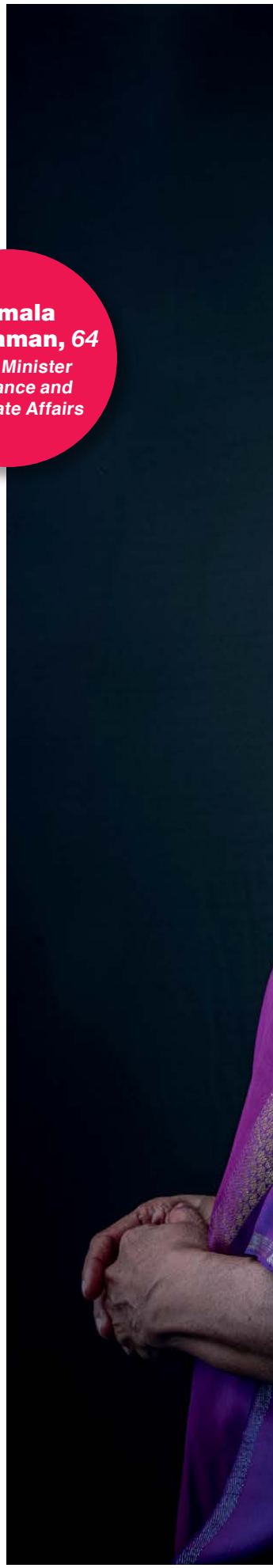
QUEEN OF THE FISC

Nirmala Sitharaman, *64*
Union Minister of Finance and Corporate Affairs



ACCOMPLISHMENT
As the country's first full-time woman finance minister, has steered the Indian economy through the crisis years darkened by Covid, bucking a global recessionary trend with a non-populist, longtermist approach

A CHILD SAVED FROM A NEAR-LETHAL bout of diphtheria in a railway hospital verandah in Tamil Nadu's Villupuram in the 1960s, a rebellious JNU student who joined a gherao of the vice-chancellor in the 1980s, a scholar who doubled up as a sales girl with the best Christmas numbers at a home décor store on London's Regent Street, a fixture in the Forbes 50 Most Powerful Women list.... If you draw a graph for the life of Nirmala Sitharaman, she'd gladly see it replicated on India's economic charts. It's not a country ever easy on its finance ministers. If being its first full-time woman FM promised to be doubly onerous, the strain rarely showed—despite the malefic hand of a pandemic that set the clock back for the whole world. Sitharaman set to her complex task with a horologist's diligence, alive at once to the urgencies of the moment and the call of the epoch. Collateral-free loans for MSMEs, concessional credit for farmers—a Rs 20 lakh crore stimulus package designed not only to revive self-adequacy but to seed the future amidst the storm. Her reforms push also saw 10 public sector banks merged into four large ones.

Both her economic vision and her politics coalesced early. She was part of the Free Thinkers at Jawaharlal Nehru University, a "forceful" campaigner in a student election where the group totally trounced the Left's SFI—an unheard-of event in that red bastion those days. Alongside, she studied economics and international trade, a body of knowledge she channelled into a brief stint researching East European economies for PricewaterhouseCoopers at London.

The love of books runs in the family: daughter Vangmayi is, inter alia, a features writer with *Mint Lounge*. Sitharaman, too, often tweets on books: from Marquez, to the anecdote-filled *Veterans of the Reserve Bank*, to Bhagavad Gita explainer *Thus Spake Krishna*. That last one must have come in handy during her turn as defence minister: another first, if you discount Mrs G. Remember Balakot? ■

–Sonal Khetarpal

↘ HIGH NOTES Sitharaman is passionate about Indian classical music, both Hindustani and Carnatic. Recently took time out to inaugurate an exhibition of ancient musical instruments in Vijayawada

↘ A WEAK SPOT Pickles. Tweeted once to say that she was "creating a year-long stock...guided by mother-in-law and elder sister-in-law"